Vivekanand Education Society's Institute of Technology



Department of Information Technology

Group No.: 39
Date :- 4/03/2026

Capstone Project - I Synopsis (2025-26) - Sem VI

Domain:- Security and Blockchain

SDG:-12 - Responsible Consumption and Production

Title of the Project

BioToken:

A Decentralized Framework for Reagent Provenance and Verification using Zero-Knowledge Proofs and Blockchain

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1. Abstract

The global biotechnology and pharmaceutical sectors are currently underpinned by a "high-trust, low-verification" supply chain model that is increasingly vulnerable to counterfeiting, environmental degradation, and data falsification. As precision medicine and synthetic biology scale, the integrity of biochemical reagents ranging from **CRISPR-Cas9 nucleases** to **monoclonal antibodies** and **specialized enzymes** becomes the single point of failure for patient safety and experimental reproducibility. This research proposes **BioToken**, a decentralized, hardware-integrated framework that establishes an immutable "Digital Birth Certificate" for any high-value biological or chemical reagent. By synthesizing **Blockchain Ledger Technology**, **Non-Fungible Tokens (NFTs)**, and **Zero-Knowledge Proofs (ZKPs)**, BioToken creates a secure link between a physical substance and its digital twin.

The innovation of this project lies in its **ZK-AI Validation** layer. Instead of requiring manufacturers to publish sensitive, proprietary chemical "fingerprints" (such as **HPLC** or **Mass Spectrometry** peaks) to a public database, the BioToken protocol utilizes a mathematical **Verification Key (vk)**. This allows end-users to locally verify that a received reagent matches the manufacturer's "Gold Standard" without either party ever exposing the raw data. Furthermore, the system implements a **Smart Contract "Kill Switch"** triggered by the physical destruction of a **frangible QR seal**, ensuring that empty high-value packaging cannot be scavenged and refilled with counterfeit substances. Preliminary analysis indicates that BioToken significantly reduces the "Trust Gap" in global biotech logistics, providing a cryptographically secured foundation for the next generation of life sciences.

2.Introduction

The modern laboratory is only as reliable as the reagents it consumes. From diagnostic testing and vaccine development to advanced gene editing, the accuracy of scientific outcomes is tethered to the chemical purity and molecular integrity of specialized biological tools. However, as the supply chain for these reagents has become globalized, it has also become opaque. Current industry standards for verification rely on Certificates of Analysis (COAs)—static PDF documents or paper inserts that are trivial to forge and offer no real-time protection against "gray market" diversion or cold-chain failures (where a reagent is chemically altered by temperature spikes without changing its visual appearance)[1],[13].

This systemic vulnerability has created a "Reagent Integrity Crisis." In clinical environments, a degraded enzyme or a mislabeled antibody can lead to false negatives in disease screening or, in the case of CRISPR-based therapies, unintended off-target genomic modifications[4]. The fundamental challenge is a technical paradox: manufacturers need to prove their product's quality to the buyer, but they cannot publicly share the detailed chemical "fingerprints" of their batches without risking the theft of trade secrets. This lack of transparency allows for the infiltration of sub-standard materials, costing the global research community billions of dollars in "irreproducible" science[9] and putting human lives at risk in therapeutic settings.

The BioToken project addresses this crisis by treating biochemical reagents as Programmable Digital Assets. By mapping the physical properties of a reagent to a unique NFT on a distributed ledger, we transition from a "Trust-Based" model to a "Verification-Based" model. This introduction details how the integration of Zero-Knowledge Cryptography allows for "Private Verification"—enabling a lab to confirm a reagent's authenticity with 100% mathematical certainty without the manufacturer losing control of their data. By establishing a decentralized "Chain of Custody" that includes an automated "Kill Switch" for consumed materials, BioToken provides the necessary infrastructure to secure the biological supply chain against the growing threats of the 21st century.

3.Problem Statement

The global supply chain for high-value biochemical reagents (such as Cas9 enzymes, monoclonal antibodies, and PCR master mixes) is currently plagued by a fundamental Insecurity of Provenance. This problem is multi-faceted, involving chemical, logistical, and cryptographic failures that compromise the integrity of biological research and clinical outcomes.

A. The "Trust Gap" and Data Asymmetry

In the current ecosystem, manufacturers possess the "Gold Standard" chemical fingerprint of a reagent batch (e.g., HPLC or Mass Spectrometry data). However, this data is proprietary. To protect their intellectual property, manufacturers provide only a simplified Certificate of Analysis (COA). This creates Data Asymmetry: the lab receiving the reagent has no immutable way to verify that the liquid in the vial matches the manufacturer's original test results[6],[11]. This lack of transparency allows for the infiltration of "gray market" or diluted reagents that appear authentic but fail under experimental conditions.

B. Physical Tampering and "Empty Bottle" Fraud

High-value reagents are often shipped in specialized, branded packaging. A critical vulnerability exists where authentic, empty containers are scavenged from laboratory waste, refilled with inferior or expired substances, and resold. Because the packaging is genuine, visual inspection is insufficient to detect the fraud[12]. Current tracking systems (like standard Barcodes or RFID) only track the *location* of the box, not the *integrity* or *consumption status* of the liquid inside.

C. Cold-Chain Fragility and Undetected Degradation

Biological materials are highly sensitive to thermal fluctuations. If a reagent exceeds its stable temperature range during transit, its molecular structure may denature, rendering it useless or dangerous. Standard logistics logs are often centralized and can be retroactively altered to hide "excursions." Without an Immutable Audit Trail, a scientist has no way of knowing if the reagent's "Digital Birth Certificate" has been compromised by environmental factors during the Factory-to-Lab journey[13].

4.Proposed Solution

The BioToken framework introduces a decentralized, end-to-end verification protocol that transforms a physical reagent into a Programmable Digital Asset. The solution utilizes a three-layered architecture: Physical Hardware, AI-Validation, and Blockchain/ZK-Cryptography.

Stage 1: The "Digital Birth" (NFT Minting)

Upon production, a batch-specific chemical fingerprint is generated. Instead of uploading this sensitive data to a public server, we use a Zero-Knowledge Circuit to create a Verification Key (vk). This vk is a mathematical "summary" that allows for verification without revealing the raw chemical peaks [2], [14]. We then mint a Non-Fungible Token (NFT) on a blockchain (e.g., Ethereum/Polygon)[10]. The NFT's metadata contains the Batch ID, expiration date, and the vk.

Stage 2: ZK-AI Validation & Local Verification

The most innovative component of the solution is the ZK-AI Prover. When the reagent arrives at the lab, the scientist performs a local chemical scan. Our Python-based AI model compares the local scan results against the manufacturer's "Gold Standard" (shared via an encrypted channel).

- If the data matches, the AI generates a Zero-Knowledge Proof (pi).
- This proof is sent to a Smart Contract on the blockchain.
- The contract runs the verify() function. If the math balances, the reagent's status is updated to VERIFIED, and ownership of the NFT is transferred to the lab.

Stage 3: The "Kill Switch" Mechanism

To solve the "Empty Bottle" fraud, BioToken implements a physical-to-digital destruction protocol. The reagent vial is sealed with a frangible QR code that self-destructs upon opening. Once the scientist uses the reagent, they trigger a "Consume" transaction on the blockchain. The Smart Contract moves the NFT status to EXPENDED. If a fraudster later scans that same QR code, the blockchain returns a "Critical Error: Token Already Dead" message, effectively neutralizing the resale value of the physical waste and ensuring that every reagent has a "Single-Use" cryptographic life cycle[12].

5.Methodology / Block Diagram

The methodology for the BioToken implementation follows a specialized **Physical-to-Digital-to-Physical (P-D-P)** loop. This ensures that every biological event (manufacturing, testing, or consumption) is reflected on the blockchain through cryptographic evidence.

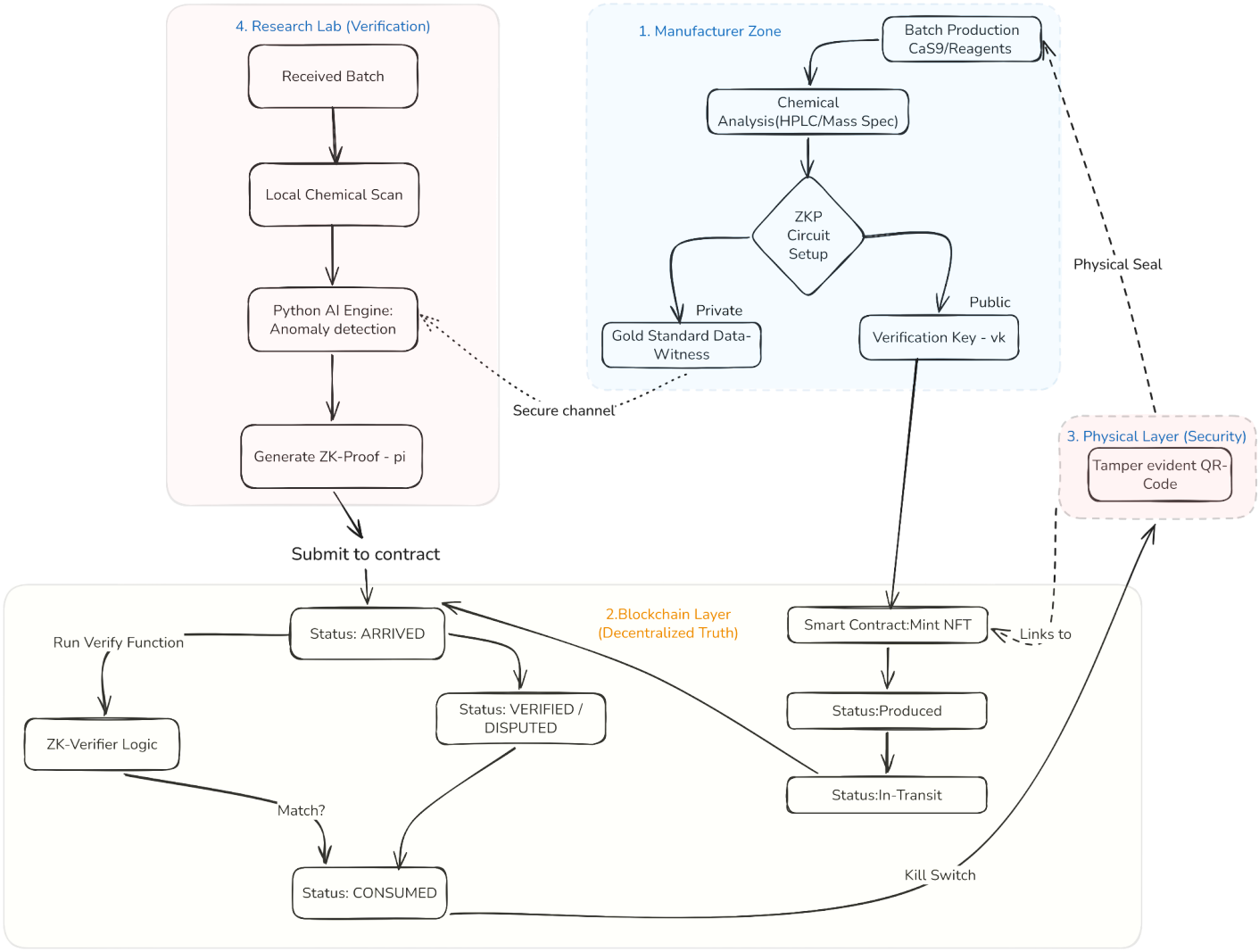


Fig 1: BioToken System Architecture – The Physical-to-Digital-to-Physical (P-D-P) Loop for Reagent Provenance

5.1 Stage 1: Data Acquisition and ZK-Circuit Synthesis

The process begins at the manufacturer's facility following the production of a reagent batch.

- **Chemical Fingerprinting:** The reagent (e.g., a Cas9 enzyme or a DNA primer) is analyzed via **High-Performance Liquid Chromatography (HPLC)[15]**. The resulting chromatogram provides a series of "peaks" representing purity and molecular weight.
- **Defining the Gold Standard:** This raw data is treated as the "Witness" (w) in a Zero-Knowledge system.

- **Circuit Compilation:** Using a ZK-framework (such as **ZoKrates** or **Circom[5]**), a circuit is compiled to generate a **Verification Key (vk)**. This vk is a mathematical representation of the "correct" chemical signature without containing the actual data points.

5.2 Stage 2: Tokenization and Secure Logistics

Once the vk is generated, it must be anchored to a decentralized ledger.

- **NFT Minting:** A Smart Contract (ERC-721 or ERC-1155) mints a **BioToken**. The vk and Batch ID are stored as immutable metadata.
- **Physical Linking:** A unique, tamper-evident **frangible QR code** is laser-etched onto a seal covering the vial cap. The hash of this QR code is mapped to the Token ID on-chain.
- **Status: IN_TRANSIT:** During shipping, the "Escrow" state is activated. Every logistics handler must sign a transaction with their private key upon receipt and handover, creating an immutable **Chain of Custody**.

5.3 Stage 3: The ZK-AI Validation Protocol (The Lab Interface)

This is the most critical technical phase, occurring upon the reagent's arrival at the destination laboratory.

- Local Sampling: The lab performs a local scan of the reagent using their own analytical hardware.
- The AI Prover: A local Python-based AI model takes two inputs: the Lab's new scan and the Manufacturer’s private Gold Standard (transmitted via a secure, one-time encrypted Peer-to-Peer channel).
- Proof Generation (pi): If the AI determines the samples match within a specific tolerance [15], it generates a Zero-Knowledge Proof (pi). This proof says: "I have the data that matches the vk on the blockchain, but I am not revealing the data itself."
- On-Chain Verification: The lab’s application sends only pi to the Smart Contract. The contract runs the verify function. If true, the status updates to VERIFIED, and ownership is transferred to the lab.

5.4 Stage 4: Post-Consumption "Kill Switch"

The final stage ensures the physical security of the reagent lifecycle.

- **The Consumption Event:** When the scientist breaks the seal to use the reagent, the frangible QR code is physically destroyed, preventing it from being scanned correctly again.
- **Digital Burn/Update:** The scientist clicks "Consume" in the BioToken App. The Smart Contract updates the NFT state to **CONSUMED**.

- **Fraud Prevention:** Any future attempt to scan or verify this specific Batch ID/Token will return a **"Token Expended"** status, rendering the empty packaging worthless to counterfeiters.

6.Hardware , Software and tools Requirements

To ensure the BioToken framework is both technically robust and environmentally sustainable, the requirement stack is divided into high-precision analytical hardware and low-energy consumption software protocols.

6.1 Hardware Requirements

- Analytical Spectrometer / HPLC System: Used at the manufacturer and laboratory levels to generate the initial and verification "chemical fingerprints" of the reagents.
- Edge Computing Node (Workstation): A standard high-performance PC or laptop (e.g., 16GB RAM, Dedicated GPU) to run the Local ZK-Prover. Performing these heavy mathematical computations locally ("at the edge") rather than on the cloud reduces data transfer energy and maintains privacy.
- Scanner/Mobile Device: For scanning the frangible QR-coded seals. No specialized hardware is needed here, making the solution accessible to any lab with a smartphone or webcam.
- Sustainable Infrastructure (Serverless): For the backend, using green-energy-certified cloud providers or local laboratory servers to minimize the carbon footprint of data storage.

6.2 Software Requirements

Blockchain Protocol: Polygon (PoS) or Ethereum (Post-Merge). These Proof-of-Stake networks consume 99.9% less energy than traditional Proof-of-Work systems [3], ensuring the sustainability of the "Digital Birth" process.

Smart Contract Development: Solidity for writing the logic of the BioToken (ERC-721/1155), including the verifyProof() and consumeToken() functions.

Zero-Knowledge Framework: ZoKrates or Circom. These tools allow the creation of the ZK-SNARK circuits required for the privacy-preserving verification of chemical data.

AI/ML Engine: Python (TensorFlow/Keras) for the local anomaly detection model. Python's extensive libraries for signal processing allow for the efficient comparison of HPLC peaks [15].

Web3 Integration: Ethers.js or Web3.py to bridge the Python AI environment with the Blockchain Smart Contracts.

Decentralized Storage: IPFS (InterPlanetary File System) for storing encrypted metadata and the Verification Keys (vk), ensuring data is not stored on a single, vulnerable central server.

7.Proposed Evaluation Measures

A sustainable and effective solution must be measured against its accuracy, efficiency, and

economic viability. The following metrics will be used to evaluate the BioToken framework's performance:

7.1 Cryptographic & AI Accuracy

Verification Success Rate: Testing the ZK-SNARK to ensure it correctly validates 100% of "Gold Standard" matches while rejecting any altered or diluted chemical data (False Positives/Negatives).

AI Sensitivity (The Degradation Threshold): Measuring the AI's ability to detect molecular degradation. The evaluation will test the model's threshold for identifying a 2–5% shift in chemical peaks caused by thermal exposure or aging.

7.2 Economic & Technical Sustainability

Gas Fee Optimization: Measuring the "Gas" (transaction cost) required for minting and verifying tokens. By using Polygon (L2), the goal is to keep verification costs under $0.20 per vial, ensuring the system is cheaper than traditional manual auditing.

Computation Latency: Measuring the "Time-to-Proof." A sustainable lab workflow requires that generating a ZK-Proof (pi) on a standard workstation takes < 60 seconds, minimizing energy draw and user downtime.

7.3 Security & Tamper Resistance

"Kill Switch" Effectiveness: Simulating "Replay Attacks" where a used QR code is scanned to see if the Smart Contract successfully blocks the transaction.

Auditability: Verifying the blockchain ledger to ensure 100% traceability from the moment of "Digital Birth" at the factory to "Consumption" at the lab.

8. Conclusion

The BioToken project presents a transformative approach to the biotechnology supply chain by bridging the physical reality of biochemical reagents with the mathematical certainty of the blockchain. While we have used CRISPR-Cas9 as a high-stakes case study, the framework is designed as a universal protocol for any high-value reagent—from life-saving vaccines to precision enzymes.

By utilizing Zero-Knowledge Proofs, we have solved the "Privacy Paradox," allowing manufacturers to prove product authenticity without revealing sensitive trade secrets. The implementation of a Smart Contract "Kill Switch" provides a robust defense against the "Empty Bottle" fraud that currently plagues the global market [12]. Furthermore, by selecting a Proof-of-Stake (PoS) architecture and edge-based AI processing, BioToken remains an environmentally sustainable solution that does not rely on energy-intensive infrastructure.

As biotechnology continues to advance toward personalized medicine, the need for an immutable, verifiable, and decentralized "Chain of Custody" becomes non-negotiable. BioToken provides this foundation, ensuring that the biological tools used to rewrite the code of life are as secure as the digital systems used to protect our wealth [6].

9.References

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